What Is Anxiety? Understanding Your Body's Alarm System

David Glenn, PMHNP, RN

Hi, I'm David Glenn. I'm a psychiatric nurse practitioner, and I've been helping people with anxiety for years.

If you're reading this, anxiety is probably making your life harder than it needs to be. Maybe you can't sleep, you're avoiding things you used to enjoy, or you just feel on edge all the time.

Here's what I want you to know: You're not broken. Anxiety isn't your fault. And with the right understanding, it gets better.

Today, we're going to figure out what anxiety actually is and why your body creates it.

What Is Anxiety?

Think of anxiety like a car alarm. A good car alarm goes off when someone's breaking in. But what if your car alarm went off every time a leaf touched it?

That's anxiety. Your brain has an alarm system to keep you safe. But sometimes it's way too sensitive.

Your brain's job is simple: keep you alive. It doesn't care if you're happy or confident. It just wants you breathing tomorrow.

So when your brain thinks there might be danger - real or not - it hits the panic button.

Three ways this shows up:

- In your body - heart racing, can't breathe, sweating, stomach in knots
- In your thoughts - "What if something bad happens? What if I mess up?"
- In your actions - avoiding places, canceling plans, checking things over and over

Normal vs. Problem Anxiety

Normal Anxiety

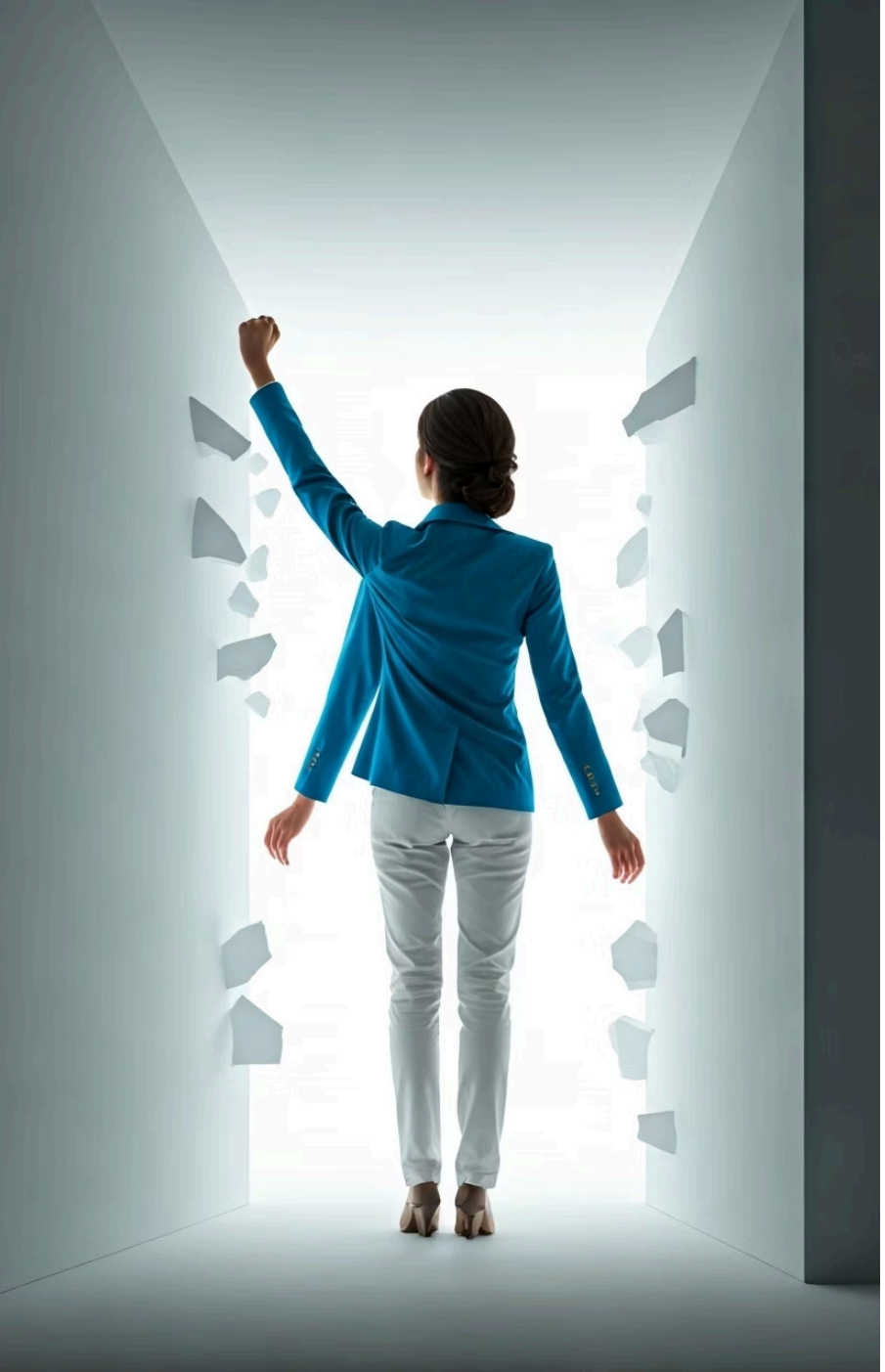
Everyone gets anxious sometimes. That's normal. Job interviews, medical tests, first dates - your brain should be a little alert.

Problem Anxiety

Problem anxiety is different:

- Shows up when you're actually safe
- Way too intense for the situation
- Sticks around too long
- Makes you avoid things that matter

The good news? This is fixable. You just need the right tools.



Breaking the Myths

"Just think positive"

Doesn't work. Anxiety isn't a thinking problem.

"You're just being dramatic"

Wrong. Anxiety is real and physical.

"Everyone gets nervous"

True, but anxiety disorders are different.

"You should be stronger"

Anxiety has nothing to do with strength.

40 million adults deal with anxiety. You're not alone, you're not weak, and you're not crazy.

What's Next

Body Check

Right now, do a quick body check. Are your shoulders tight? Jaw clenched? Holding your breath?

That's anxiety living in your body. Most people never notice this.

Pay Attention

This week, you're going to start paying attention. Not to judge yourself, but to understand your patterns.

Identify Triggers

Next week, we'll figure out what specifically triggers YOUR anxiety. Once you know your triggers, you can get ahead of them.

You took a big step being here. That takes courage. Be proud of that.

Your anxiety can get better. Let's do this together.

More about David Glenn

About David Glenn, PMHNP-BC

David Glenn is not only a board-certified psychiatric nurse practitioner—he's also a dedicated advocate for mental wellness in his community. Dave's clinical expertise spans anxiety disorders, depression, trauma, and holistic approaches to mental health. He is known for his approachable, down-to-earth style and his ability to make complex topics feel understandable and manageable.

Dave founded Real Psychiatric Services to create a safe, welcoming space for people to get the support they deserve—without judgment or barriers. He believes that everyone's story matters, and that healing is possible for all.

"I created this course because I've seen firsthand how understanding anxiety can change lives. My hope is that you'll find practical tools, encouragement, and a sense of community here. You're not alone—and you don't have to do this alone."

For more about Dave's background, philosophy, and the full provider team, visit:
realpsychiatricservices.com/meet-your-providers